



We prefer individuals who are passionate about Linux / Open Source and choose to work on these technologies as part of their academics”

Naresh Shah
Managing Director
Novell India
Development Centre

Besides the existence of free Linux distributions, the presence of two major Linux vendors—Red Hat and Novell—has boosted adoption amongst Indian enterprises. Many companies are getting their workforce accustomed to working with Linux. It offers lower cost of ownership, a variety of open source software packs, and support for different hardware platforms. Different industries, from BPOs and ITES-enabled organisations to Banking, Finance and Insurance Services (BFSI) all use Linux for mission-critical operations.

Linux is now being used for servers as well as Desktops in enterprises such as AirTel, ABN Amro, BSNL, Canara Bank, New India Assurance, UTI Bank, and others. Even the governments of Kerala, Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu, and West Bengal have started adopting Linux in their offices.

Opportunity Knocks

The Linux platform is vast and diverse, and there are ample career opportunities available for enthusiasts. Technologists supporting open source—as well as, of course, geeks—believe Linux is a user-friendly operating system. True, Linux is indeed flexible—customisable and configurable according to requirement. For that customisation, professionals who know Linux in and out are in high demand.

Linux “fanboys” and active members of the open source community in general have a natural ability to fix problems as they occur. The fact is, it takes an enthusiast—or at least a very interested mind—to dabble in Linux.

Enterprises with different businesses and goals will have different IT requirements for their business operations. For instance, the requirements of mobile payment services like PayMate would be different from those of the online payment services offered by HDFC Bank. Both require their software applications and database to be accessible to their customers or clients. Handling such environments demands the Linux professional’s good analytical and logical skills coupled with inquisitiveness of mind.

Linux, in terms of career opportunities, can offer jobs in the areas mentioned here. Suitable education and training is required in any area, but don’t underestimate self-learning through practical application which is as important, if not more so, than the former.

Tech Support / Help Desk

Support for Linux is not easily available; not many certified professionals are available for tech support. Demand of Linux tech support professionals lies in providing solutions across the spectrum from installing, optimising, troubleshooting, and code debugging of Linux installations. It also includes any maintenance and support work on the computers of a company. Knowledge of different Linux OS flavours and widely-used open source applications such as the OpenOffice suite is expected from them, along with good hardware competency.

Programming Software Development

Software development on the Linux platform is very different from that for Windows. Programmers for Linux have to write code such that the application is interoperable with Windows or other platforms. Programmers with proficiency in languages like C++, JAVA, Perl, Ruby on Rails, and Python for Linux fit this segment. There are companies getting into development of cross-platform software packages that are used in Desktops and even mobile devices.

Web Development

Many Web hosting companies rely on Linux-based servers for hosting their Web site, databases, applications, and other development work. A sizable requirement for Web developers on the Linux platform exists. At present, demand for LAMP developers is high. LAMP stands for “Linux, Apache, MySQL and PHP”. Besides this, candidates proficient with Web technologies and in programming as well as scripting languages like Perl, Java, Ruby on Rails, and Python can choose to enter the Web development domain.

Saravanan Arumugam, Founder & CEO, Lynus Academy, which imparts training for Linux and open source software, speaks about the scarcity of Web developers for Linux: “A large number of Web development companies today suffer from a scarcity of Linux professionals holding the LAMP certification.”

Kernel And Device Drivers Development

Areas like chip designing, embedded devices and systems, embedded Linux, etc. require programming of the Linux kernel to work in real-time. Therefore Linux distribution meant for real-time programming and operations such as VxWorks, RT Linux, and others are used to perform specific functions and develop device drivers for chips for embedded devices. These programmers should be comfortable working with hardware languages such as Verilog and VHDL for Real-Time Linux design / model development.

“A high demand for Linux professionals is observed in applications development and device drivers for Linux-based systems,” says Naresh Shah, Managing Director, Novell India Development Center, the second-largest R&D centre for Novell worldwide.

What They Do, What They Are	
Functional Area	Designation
System Administration, Network Administration, Network Security, Web Server Administration	☐ Linux System Administrator ☐ Linux Network Administrator ☐ Network Security Engineer / Analyst
Desktop Management and Maintenance	☐ Technical Support Associate
Database Administration	☐ Database Administrator
Linux System Development Kernel Development Device Driver Development Application Development Web Application Development	☐ Software Engineer